

Food Insecurity and Poverty in Canada

A plain-English look at why millions of Canadians cannot afford to eat and what the data tells us about why

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Data: Statistics Canada 2021 Census of Population; Canadian Income Survey 2018 to 2024; Uppal (2023), Statistics Canada Catalogue 75-006-X

10 million	Canadians living in a food-insecure household in 2024
+43%	Rise in food insecurity since 2018, the fastest increase in Canadian history
78%	Of food-insecure households are employed and living above the official poverty line
40.6%	Of Black Canadian families experienced food insecurity in 2022, nearly double the national rate

This report uses publicly available Statistics Canada data to examine why food insecurity is rising in Canada and which structural conditions drive it. It is written for a general audience. No economics background is required.

Why Are So Many Canadians Going Hungry?

One in four Canadians could not reliably afford food in 2024. That is 10 million people in one of the wealthiest countries on earth, struggling to put consistent meals on the table. The number has nearly doubled since 2019. And yet, when you look at who those people are, the story gets surprising.

They are not, for the most part, unemployed. They are not, in most cases, living below the official poverty line. The majority of food-insecure Canadians have jobs, earn income, and technically fall above the threshold the government defines as poverty. This is the central paradox this report investigates: if people are working and earning, why are they still going hungry?

The short answer, which the data confirms, is that food insecurity in Canada is a structural problem. It is not caused by individual failure. It is caused by the interaction of housing costs that consume too much income, labour markets that do not pay enough to cover the basics, and a social safety net that was not designed for the economic conditions of the 2020s. On top of that, the burden falls hardest on people who face additional barriers because of race, Indigenous identity, or family circumstance.

This report investigates four questions. Does earning more money protect you from hunger, or do housing costs cancel out that advantage? Why does Quebec consistently have the lowest hunger rates in Canada despite not being the richest province? Has the connection between unemployment and hunger broken down? And which combination of structural conditions puts a province most at risk?

Where This Analysis Comes From

The author worked as a Building Operator across 13 properties in Vancouver's Downtown Eastside between 2023 and 2025. The Downtown Eastside is Canada's most studied neighbourhood for concentrated poverty, food insecurity, housing instability, and addiction. Working there every day makes it clear that the people struggling are not struggling because of personal choices. They are struggling because of the conditions they were placed into and the structural barriers that make it almost impossible to get out. This analysis attempts to show, in numbers, what that looks like at a national scale.

The Data: Where the Numbers Come From

This report draws on three datasets, all from Statistics Canada, which is the Canadian government agency responsible for collecting official national data. Statistics Canada runs the national Census every five years and surveys Canadians annually on income and living conditions. These are the most reliable, comprehensive sources of information about poverty and food insecurity in Canada.

The first dataset is the 2021 Census of Population, which collected detailed information about income, housing costs, employment, and inequality from every province and territory. The second is a city-level version of the same Census, covering the 41 largest urban areas in Canada. The third is the Canadian Income Survey, which has been tracking food insecurity annually since 2018 and provides data up to 2024.

One important note about the data: the Census income figures refer to the year 2020, which was the height of the COVID pandemic. This means some income numbers were temporarily boosted by government emergency payments, and some unemployment figures were elevated by temporary pandemic job losses. This is acknowledged throughout the analysis where it is relevant.

Understanding the Key Measurements

Before looking at the results, it helps to understand what each measurement actually means. These terms appear throughout this report and in the charts.

Food insecurity

A household is food insecure when it cannot reliably afford enough food due to lack of money. Statistics Canada measures this in three levels. Marginal food insecurity means a household worries about running out of food or has to limit food choices because of cost. Moderate food insecurity means the quality or quantity of food is actually reduced because of money. Severe food insecurity means people are skipping meals or going whole days without eating. The food insecurity rate reported throughout this analysis includes all three levels combined.

Median household income

The median is the middle point. If you lined up all households in a province from lowest to highest income, the median is the income of the household exactly in the middle. Half of households earn more than this, and half earn less. It is a better measure of typical income than the average, because a small number of very wealthy households can make the average look higher than what most people actually earn.

LIM-AT (Low Income Measure, After Tax)

This tells you what percentage of people in a province earn significantly less than most other Canadians. Specifically, it counts anyone whose household income falls below half the national median income after taxes. If the typical Canadian household takes home 73,000 dollars per year, anyone earning less than 36,500 dollars falls below this line. It is a relative measure of poverty, meaning it captures how far behind some people are compared to everyone else, not just whether they can survive.

Gini index

The Gini index is a single number that captures how evenly or unevenly money is distributed in a place. Think of a classroom. If every student in the class earned exactly the same income, the Gini would be zero. If one student earned everything and everyone else earned nothing, the Gini would be one. Every real society sits somewhere in between. Canadian provinces range from about 0.27 to 0.31. A lower Gini means incomes are more evenly spread. Quebec, at 0.28, is the most equal province. Ontario, at 0.31, has the widest gap between rich and poor.

Tenant shelter burden

This measures the percentage of people who rent their home and spend 30 percent or more of their income on housing. Housing experts use 30 percent as the threshold beyond which housing is considered unaffordable, because it leaves too little money for everything else, including food. A high shelter burden in a province means a large share of renters are being financially squeezed by their housing costs.

Vulnerability index

The vulnerability index in this report is a score built specifically for this analysis. It combines five structural indicators, each rescaled to the same range, and averages them into a single number. A higher score means a province has worse conditions across multiple dimensions simultaneously. It is a way of asking: setting food insecurity aside as the outcome we are trying to explain, which provinces are structurally most at risk of it?

How the Structural Indicators Relate to Each Other

Before asking which factors cause food insecurity, it is useful to understand how all the structural indicators relate to each other. The chart below is called a correlation matrix. It is a grid that shows, for every pair of indicators, how strongly they move together across the ten provinces.

Reading the chart is straightforward. Each cell in the grid shows a number. A number close to 1.0 means those two indicators tend to go up and down together, so provinces that score high on one tend to score high on the other. A number close to negative 1.0 means they move in opposite directions, so provinces high on one tend to be low on the other. A number close to zero means the two have no meaningful relationship. Darker red cells indicate stronger positive relationships. Darker green cells indicate stronger negative ones. The diagonal running from top left to bottom right always shows 1.0 because every indicator perfectly correlates with itself.

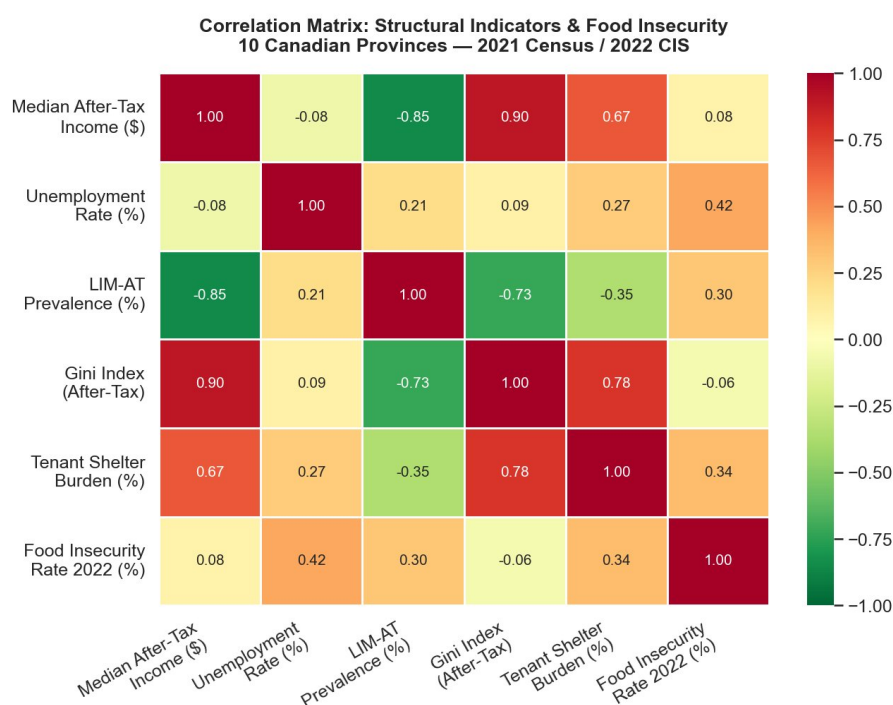


Figure 1. How six structural indicators relate to each other across the ten Canadian provinces. Numbers close to 1.0 mean both indicators tend to be high in the same provinces. Numbers close to negative 1.0 mean they move in opposite directions.

What the correlation chart tells us

The single most striking number is the 0.08 in the bottom left area of the chart, where the Food Insecurity row meets the Median After-Tax Income column. That is essentially zero. It tells us that across the ten provinces, earning more money has almost no relationship with lower food insecurity. Alberta has the highest median income in Canada at 83,000 dollars per household, and it still has one of the highest food insecurity rates. Quebec has among the lowest median incomes at 63,200 dollars, and it has by far the lowest food insecurity. The income story is not the food

insecurity story.

The strongest relationship in the entire chart is the negative 0.85 between income and LIM-AT. That makes intuitive sense. Provinces where households earn more tend to have fewer people falling far below the national median. What is more interesting, and more surprising, is the 0.90 between income and the Gini index. That means the highest-income provinces also tend to have the widest gaps between rich and poor. British Columbia and Alberta are the clearest examples: high overall income, but also the most unequal distribution of that income.

The relationship between tenant shelter burden and food insecurity, at 0.34, is the strongest direct link to hunger in the whole chart. It is not huge, but it is the most consistent structural signal. Provinces where more renters are spending 30 percent or more of their income on housing tend to have higher food insecurity, which makes practical sense. If your rent takes most of your paycheque, there is less left for groceries.

Does Earning More Protect You From Hunger?

This is perhaps the most natural assumption people make about food insecurity: surely it is a problem for poor provinces, and richer provinces must be doing better. The data says otherwise.



Figure 2. Left chart: median household income compared to food insecurity rate for each province in 2022. Right chart: income inequality (Gini index) compared to food insecurity. If income protected against hunger, both charts would show a clear downward slope. Instead, the lines are almost completely flat.

How to read these charts

Each dot in the left chart represents one province. Moving right on the horizontal axis means higher median income. Moving up on the vertical axis means higher food insecurity. If income protected against hunger, all the dots would slope downward from left to right, meaning the higher the income, the lower the food insecurity. The grey dashed line shows the actual trend. It is almost perfectly flat, sloping very gently upward, which statistically confirms that income and food insecurity have essentially no relationship at all across the provinces.

What the data actually shows

Alberta is in the top right corner of the chart. It has the highest median household income of any province, at 83,000 dollars a year after tax. It also has a food insecurity rate of 28.2 percent, meaning more than one in four Albertan families struggled to afford food in 2022. That is the fourth highest rate in the country.

Prince Edward Island is in a similar position. It has a median income of 64,000 dollars and the highest food insecurity rate in the country at 30.1 percent. New Brunswick has the lowest median income at 62,000 dollars and a food insecurity rate of 25.3 percent. Higher income, worse outcomes. Lower income, better outcomes in some cases. The pattern is completely scrambled.

The province in the bottom left, standing completely apart from everyone else, is Quebec. It has a median income of 63,200 dollars, tied with Newfoundland for third lowest in the country. But its food insecurity rate is just 15.8 percent, the lowest by a wide margin. Quebec is not protecting its people from hunger because of higher incomes. Something else entirely is going on there, which the next section explores.

The right chart asks a different version of the same question: does income inequality predict hunger? Provinces where the gap between rich and poor is wider might be expected to have more hungry people at the bottom. The answer, again, is no. The relationship is essentially zero. Ontario and British Columbia have the most unequal income distributions in the country, but they sit in the middle of the food insecurity range, not at the top.

The conclusion is clear. At the provincial level in Canada, neither how much the typical household earns nor how unevenly income is distributed explains which provinces have the most hungry people. Something structural is at work that income statistics alone cannot capture.

Why Quebec Is Different From Everyone Else

Quebec is the outlier in almost every chart in this report. It consistently shows the lowest food insecurity of any province, and the gap between Quebec and the rest of Canada is not small. In 2022, the national average was 23.1 percent. Quebec was at 15.8 percent. In a country where food insecurity has been climbing steeply, Quebec barely moved.

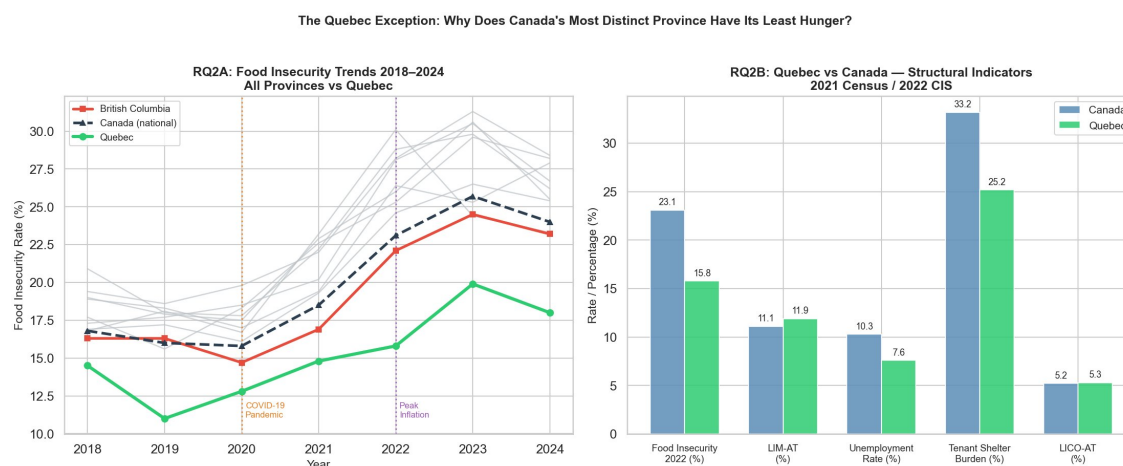


Figure 3. Left: food insecurity rates in all provinces from 2018 to 2024. The green line is Quebec. Every other province surged upward after 2020. Quebec rose only modestly. Right: a direct comparison of five structural indicators between Quebec and the Canadian national average.

How to read these charts

The left chart is a timeline. Each line represents one province. Moving right means moving forward in time from 2018 to 2024. Moving up means food insecurity is rising. The vertical dotted lines mark two important moments: 2020, when COVID arrived in Canada, and 2022, when inflation peaked at the highest level in 40 years. The dark dashed line is the national average. The green line, which runs significantly below everything else for the entire period, is Quebec.

The right chart compares five measurements side by side for Quebec (green bars) and Canada as a whole (blue bars). A shorter bar is better for food security. The most important comparison is the tenant shelter burden column on the right side.

What the Quebec difference actually is

The most revealing number in the right chart is the housing cost column. In the average Canadian province, 33.2 percent of renters spend 30 percent or more of their income on housing. In Quebec, only 25.2 percent do. That is an 8 percentage point difference, and it is the single biggest structural gap between Quebec and everywhere else. When renters in Quebec pay their rent, they have significantly more money left over for food.

The unemployment comparison is also meaningful. Quebec's unemployment rate is 7.6 percent, the lowest among all provinces, compared to the national average of 10.3 percent. More Quebecers are working, and those who are working are not bleeding as much of their paycheque into rent.

But the structural explanation goes deeper than just the numbers. Quebec has 10 dollar per day childcare, which dramatically reduces the financial pressure on families with young children. It has stronger rent controls than most other provinces, which slows the growth of housing costs. It has a more comprehensive social assistance system. These are policy choices, not accidents of geography or wealth.

The COVID comparison in the left chart is particularly powerful. When the pandemic hit in 2020, food insecurity actually dipped briefly in most provinces because the federal government sent emergency income payments to millions of Canadians. Then from 2021 onward, as emergency payments ended and inflation took hold, food insecurity exploded almost everywhere. Every province except Quebec saw its rate climb steeply. Quebec's rate barely shifted between 2019 and 2022. It was the only province to be essentially unaffected by the most severe economic shock in a generation.

This is what social scientists call a natural experiment. Quebec did not have a pandemic exemption. It faced the same inflation, the same job disruptions, the same economic pressures as the rest of Canada. The difference is that its structural programs cushioned people against those shocks in ways that other provinces could not match. The lesson is not that Quebec is richer. The lesson is that how a society is structured matters more than how wealthy it is.

Has Unemployment Stopped Explaining Hunger?

For most of economic history, the connection between unemployment and hunger was treated as obvious. If people do not have jobs, they do not have money. If they do not have money, they cannot afford food. The solution, accordingly, was to get people employed.

That logic is now breaking down in Canada. The data shows it clearly.

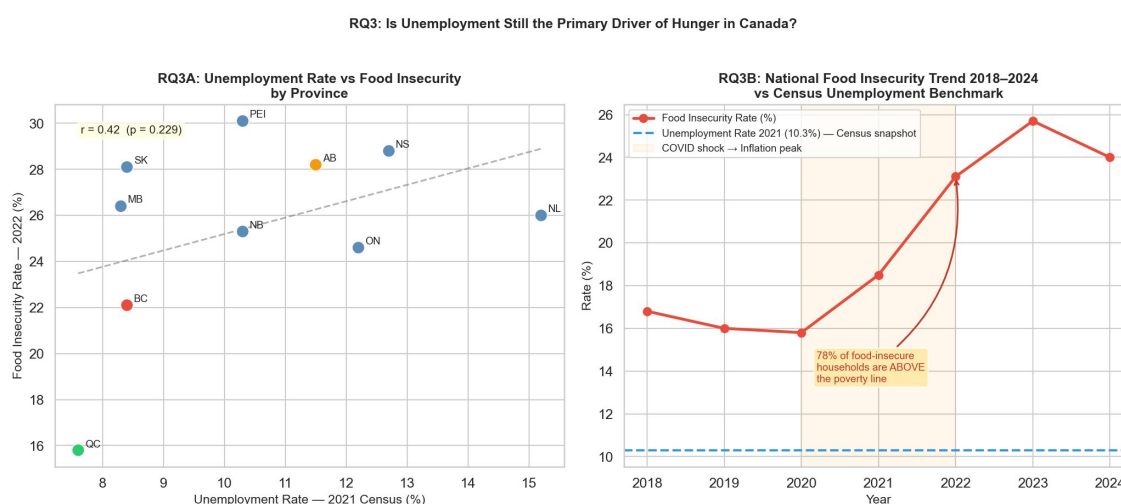


Figure 4. Left: unemployment rate compared to food insecurity rate by province in 2022. Right: how national food insecurity has changed from 2018 to 2024 compared to the unemployment rate snapshot from the 2021 Census.

How to read these charts

The left chart works the same way as the income chart in the previous section. Each dot is a province. Moving right means higher unemployment. Moving up means higher food insecurity. If unemployment caused hunger in a straightforward way, the dots would slope upward from left to right. There is a slight upward slope, but it is weak and statistically not reliable. The correlation is 0.42, which sounds meaningful but with only ten provinces it does not clear the threshold of statistical significance.

The right chart plots the national food insecurity rate each year as a red line with circles. The blue dashed line shows the unemployment rate from the 2021 Census, which sits at 10.3 percent. The shaded orange area marks the period from the COVID shock through to peak inflation. The annotation in the middle notes that 78 percent of food-insecure households are employed and above the poverty line.

What the trend tells us

The most important thing in the right chart is the distance between the red line and the blue dashed line. In 2018, food insecurity was at 16.8 percent. By 2023, it had risen to 25.7 percent, an increase of nearly 9 percentage points in just five years. The unemployment rate, meanwhile, stayed roughly

stable. These two series have completely separated from each other. Food insecurity has been rising sharply in an environment of broadly stable employment.

The annotation in the chart captures why. A landmark Statistics Canada study by Uppal (2023) found that 78 percent of all food-insecure families in Canada were not unemployed. They had jobs. They were earning money. But their income was not enough to cover their costs, primarily because housing had become so expensive and wages had not kept pace. Working full time is no longer a guarantee of being able to afford food.

Looking at the provincial scatter plot, Saskatchewan, Manitoba, and Nova Scotia all have moderate or low unemployment but very high food insecurity. Alberta has substantial unemployment but also one of the highest incomes. British Columbia has low unemployment but still ranks above the national average on food insecurity. The scatter is messy because unemployment is simply not the right lens for understanding who goes hungry anymore.

What has replaced unemployment as the primary driver? Housing costs that consume too much of a paycheck. Stagnant wages in sectors with high turnover. Precarious work, meaning part-time or contract jobs with no guaranteed hours or benefits. And on top of all of that, the specific barriers faced by racialized and Indigenous workers who earn less for equivalent work and face discrimination in housing and labour markets.

Which Provinces Are Most at Risk and Why?

Rather than looking at one factor at a time, this section combines five structural indicators into a single vulnerability score for each province. The score does not include food insecurity itself. It is built entirely from the structural conditions that are hypothesized to drive food insecurity. The question is whether provinces with worse structural conditions also end up with higher hunger rates.

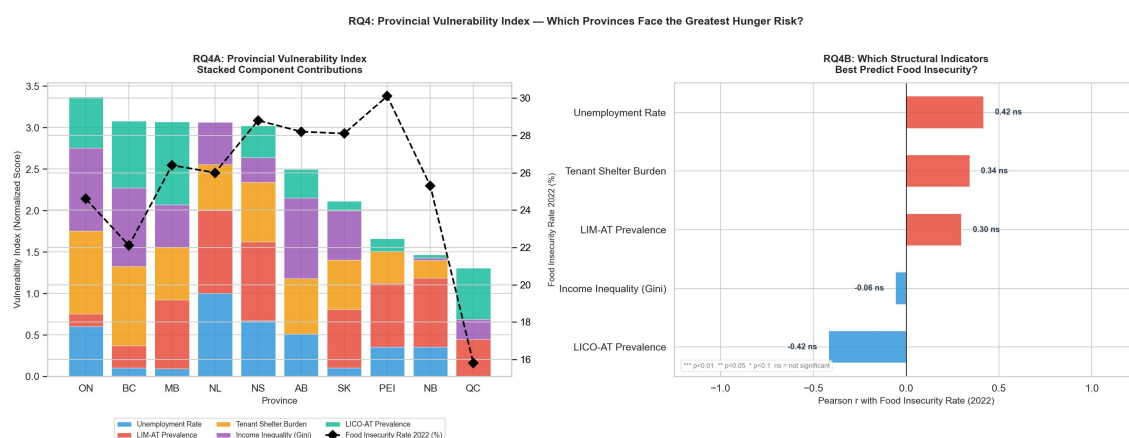


Figure 5. Left: the provincial vulnerability index, with each coloured section showing the contribution of one structural indicator to the total score. The black diamond line overlaid on the bars shows the actual food insecurity rate for comparison. Right: how well each individual structural indicator predicts food insecurity on its own.

How to read these charts

In the left chart, each bar represents a province and is divided into five coloured sections. Each colour is one structural indicator: unemployment, poverty rate, housing burden, income inequality, and LICO-AT. The height of the whole bar is the total vulnerability score, and taller bars mean a province has worse structural conditions overall. The provinces are ordered from most to least vulnerable, left to right. Ontario is on the far left, most vulnerable. Quebec is on the far right, least vulnerable.

The black diamond line running across the top shows the actual food insecurity rate for each province. If the vulnerability score perfectly predicted food insecurity, the diamond line would follow the same downward slope as the bars. It does not follow it exactly, but there is a general alignment: provinces with higher vulnerability scores tend toward higher food insecurity, with Quebec as the clearest case of low structural vulnerability matching low food insecurity.

The right chart asks a simpler question. For each of the five structural indicators, how strongly does it individually predict food insecurity across the provinces? The length of each bar shows the strength. A bar extending to the right is a positive relationship, meaning higher values of that indicator are associated with more food insecurity. A bar extending left is a negative relationship. The numbers at the end of each bar are the correlation values, and the letters after them show

statistical significance: ns means not statistically significant with ten data points.

The index rankings

Rank	Province	Vulnerability Score	Actual Food Insecurity 2022
1st	Ontario	0.674	24.6%
2nd	British Columbia	0.616	22.1%
3rd	Manitoba	0.614	26.4%
4th	Newfoundland and Labrador	0.613	26.0%
5th	Nova Scotia	0.605	28.8%
6th	Alberta	0.500	28.2%
7th	Saskatchewan	0.423	28.1%
8th	Prince Edward Island	0.332	30.1%
9th	New Brunswick	0.293	25.3%
10th	Quebec	0.262	15.8%

Ontario and British Columbia rank as the most structurally vulnerable provinces. This is a notable finding because neither Ontario nor BC has the highest food insecurity rate. Ontario is at 24.6 percent and BC is at 22.1 percent, both near the national average. But their structural conditions, particularly housing costs, income inequality, and the proportion of people in relative poverty, place them at the highest risk. They are being partially protected by other factors, perhaps higher average wages or larger urban social services, but the underlying structural exposure is severe.

Quebec sits at the bottom of the vulnerability ranking with a score of 0.262, more than twice as low as Ontario's 0.674. This aligns with its food insecurity outcome perfectly. The structural conditions are better, and the food insecurity result is better.

The most counterintuitive finding is that Prince Edward Island, which has the highest food insecurity rate in Canada at 30.1 percent, ranks only 8th on structural vulnerability. Its structural scores are not alarming on any individual indicator. This suggests that PEI may be suffering from factors the index does not capture, such as the seasonal nature of its economy, its reliance on tourism and agriculture, or weaker access to food banks and emergency services in a smaller, more rural province.

The right chart confirms that no single structural indicator is a decisive predictor of food insecurity on its own. None of the five indicators achieve statistical significance individually. This is actually an important finding. It means food insecurity is not caused by any one thing you can simply fix in isolation. It requires addressing multiple structural conditions at the same time.

Zooming Into Cities: What Urban Canada Tells Us

Provincial data shows broad patterns, but it averages over a lot of internal variation. Cities tell a more detailed story. The chart below brings together data from Canada's seven largest urban centres, combining Census information about income, inequality, and housing costs with food insecurity rates published by Statistics Canada for those cities.

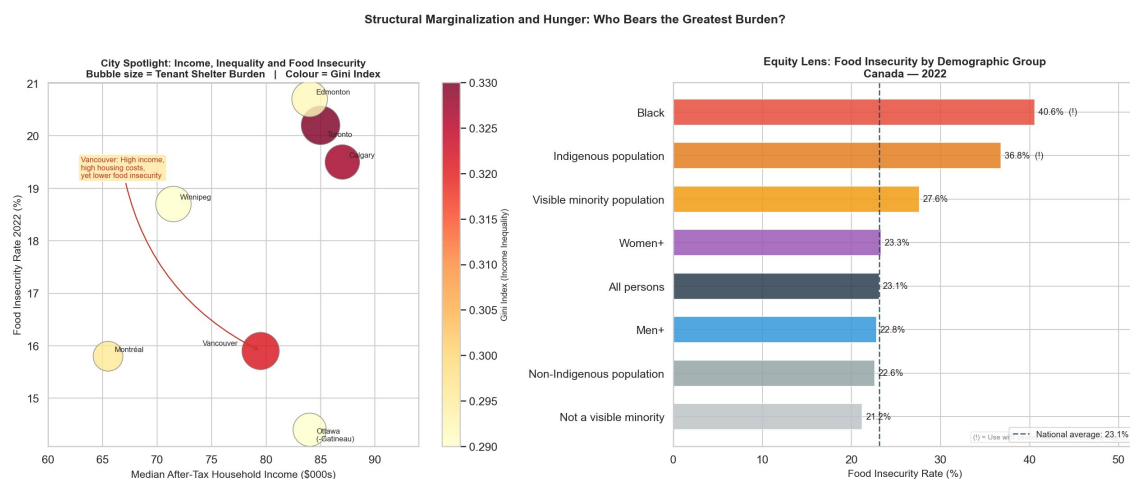


Figure 6. Left: the seven largest Canadian cities compared by income and food insecurity. Each bubble represents a city. Bigger bubbles mean higher housing cost burden on renters. Darker red colour means higher income inequality. Right: food insecurity rates broken down by demographic group across Canada in 2022.

How to read these charts

In the left chart, each bubble is a city. Moving right on the horizontal axis means higher median income. Moving up means higher food insecurity. The size of the bubble represents the housing cost burden: bigger bubbles mean more renters are spending 30 percent or more of income on housing. The colour of the bubble represents income inequality: darker red means more unequal.

In the right chart, each bar represents one demographic group in Canada. The length of the bar shows that group's food insecurity rate. The vertical dashed line marks the national average of 23.1 percent. Bars extending to the right of that line mean that group experiences more food insecurity than average. The label (!) appears next to two groups because Statistics Canada flagged those estimates as having higher statistical uncertainty and recommends using them with caution.

The Vancouver puzzle

Vancouver is the most interesting city in the chart. It has the largest bubble, meaning it has the highest housing cost burden: 38.5 percent of Vancouver renters spend 30 percent or more of their income on housing. It is also among the darker bubbles, meaning high income inequality. And yet its food insecurity rate of 15.9 percent is the second lowest among the seven cities, nearly tied with Montreal.

How can a city with the most expensive rents and high inequality still have relatively low hunger? Part of the answer lies in British Columbia's social assistance structure and the fact that Vancouver has a very large professional population whose high incomes pull the median up. Part of it may be the specific demographics of who lives in Vancouver's rental market. And part of it may simply be that the aggregate city statistic hides enormous internal variation. The Downtown Eastside, which this report's author worked in, has food insecurity rates that would be far higher than the city average. The city number is an average, and averages can hide the most severe suffering.

Edmonton and Toronto sit at the top of the chart, with food insecurity rates above 20 percent. Calgary is close behind. All three are large, relatively high-income cities, yet all three have substantial hunger problems. Calgary stands out particularly: it has the highest median income of the seven cities at 87,000 dollars, but its food insecurity rate of 19.5 percent is still near the national average.

Who bears the heaviest burden

The right chart is perhaps the most important in the entire report for understanding who food insecurity actually affects.

Black Canadian families experienced food insecurity at a rate of 40.6 percent in 2022. That is nearly double the national average of 23.1 percent. Almost half of all Black Canadian families reported struggling to afford food. Indigenous peoples experienced food insecurity at 36.8 percent. Visible minority populations as a whole were at 27.6 percent. These disparities exist not just for people living below the poverty line. Research by Uppal (2023) shows they persist for racialized and Indigenous families even when incomes are higher. A Black Canadian family earning above the poverty line is still more than twice as likely to be food insecure as a non-racialized family earning the same income.

This is the clearest evidence that food insecurity in Canada is not simply an income problem. It reflects the accumulated weight of discrimination in labour markets, where racialized workers are more likely to be in precarious, lower-paid jobs. It reflects discrimination in housing markets, where racialized families are more likely to face barriers to affordable rental housing. And it reflects the intergenerational effects of colonization and residential schools, which have stripped Indigenous communities of the economic foundations that other Canadians take for granted.

Female lone-parent families, not shown separately in this chart but documented extensively in the underlying research, face food insecurity at 41.4 percent, the highest rate of any family type. These are families where a single mother is responsible for housing, food, childcare, and income simultaneously, with typically lower earnings than male counterparts and higher costs than childless households.

Seven Years of Growing Hunger

Looking at the full 2018 to 2024 trend for all provinces provides important context for everything discussed so far. Canada did not always have a food insecurity rate of 24 percent. It was 16.8 percent in 2018. The surge is recent, rapid, and concentrated in specific provinces.

Province	2018	2019	2020	2021	2022	2023	2024
Canada	16.8%	16.0%	15.8%	18.5%	23.1%	25.7%	24.0%
Quebec	14.5%	11.0%	12.8%	14.8%	15.8%	19.9%	18.0%
British Columbia	16.3%	16.3%	14.7%	16.9%	22.1%	24.5%	23.2%
Ontario	16.9%	17.2%	16.1%	19.3%	24.6%	26.5%	25.4%
Alberta	19.4%	18.6%	19.8%	22.0%	28.2%	31.3%	28.4%
Nova Scotia	20.9%	18.0%	17.8%	22.2%	28.8%	29.8%	26.2%
Saskatchewan	17.3%	17.7%	18.5%	20.2%	28.1%	30.5%	26.7%
Prince Edward Island	16.8%	18.1%	16.7%	23.2%	30.1%	24.4%	23.3%
Manitoba	18.9%	18.3%	17.0%	19.4%	26.4%	25.3%	27.9%
New Brunswick	17.7%	15.6%	18.3%	22.6%	25.3%	29.6%	28.2%
Newfoundland	19.0%	17.9%	17.5%	22.9%	26.0%	30.6%	25.5%

A few things stand out from this table. First, food insecurity actually fell or stayed flat in 2019 and 2020 in most provinces. That is almost certainly because the federal government deployed massive emergency income supports during the pandemic: the Canada Emergency Response Benefit, which paid 2,000 dollars per month to millions of workers who lost their jobs or hours. The data confirms that direct income transfers work. When people have money, they can afford food.

Second, the surge from 2021 onward was driven primarily by inflation. When emergency payments ended and prices began rising sharply, households that had been just barely keeping up were suddenly unable to cover their costs. Grocery prices in Canada rose 8.8 percent in a single year in 2022, the largest increase in 40 years. Rent increases followed shortly behind.

Third, the recent plateau or slight decline between 2023 and 2024 in some provinces may reflect inflation beginning to ease and some wages catching up. But food insecurity in 2024 is still 43 percent higher than it was in 2018, and 10 million Canadians are still struggling.

Not All Hunger Is the Same

The overall food insecurity rate combines three levels of hardship. Understanding how severe the problem is for different provinces requires looking at them separately.

Province	Marginal	Moderate	Severe	Total
Alberta	7.2%	12.7%	8.2%	28.2%
British Columbia	6.4%	9.9%	5.8%	22.1%
Canada	6.0%	11.0%	6.1%	23.1%
Manitoba	7.2%	11.7%	7.4%	26.4%
New Brunswick	6.2%	11.1%	8.0%	25.3%
Newfoundland	6.2%	11.0%	8.8%	26.0%
Nova Scotia	6.1%	15.2%	7.4%	28.8%
Ontario	5.9%	11.9%	6.8%	24.6%
Prince Edward Island	7.7%	16.5%	5.9%	30.1%
Quebec	5.0%	8.0%	2.9%	15.8%
Saskatchewan	7.9%	13.2%	7.0%	28.1%

Marginal food insecurity means worrying about running out of food or having limited choices due to cost. Moderate means actually compromising on the quality or quantity of what you eat. Severe means skipping meals or going days without eating.

Quebec's severe food insecurity rate of 2.9 percent is the most striking number in this table. The national average is 6.1 percent, more than double Quebec's rate. In Newfoundland, 8.8 percent of the population is experiencing severe food insecurity, meaning skipping meals or going without food. In Alberta, the figure is 8.2 percent, despite being the highest-income province. In Nova Scotia, 7.4 percent of the population is severely food insecure.

Prince Edward Island has the highest overall rate at 30.1 percent, driven heavily by its moderate category at 16.5 percent. This suggests that in PEI, the problem is widespread but somewhat less concentrated at the most extreme end, unlike Newfoundland or Alberta where severe food insecurity is particularly high.

What the Evidence Tells Us

Across all four research questions and all of the data examined in this report, a consistent picture emerges. Hunger in Canada is not random, and it is not simply a consequence of people not working hard enough or provinces not being wealthy enough. It is a structural phenomenon with identifiable causes and, importantly, with identifiable solutions.

Finding one: Income does not protect against hunger

The relationship between how much the typical household earns in a province and how much food insecurity exists in that province is essentially zero. Alberta earns the most and has among the worst food insecurity. Quebec earns among the least and has by far the best outcomes. The same pattern holds at the city level. Calgary, with the highest median income among major Canadian cities at 87,000 dollars, still has nearly 20 percent of its families struggling with food. Rising median incomes, without addressing housing costs and income distribution, will not solve Canada's hunger problem.

Finding two: Social policy design is the decisive factor

The Quebec evidence is the most powerful finding in this entire report. A province with below-average incomes, no special natural resource wealth, and the same pandemic and inflation pressures as every other province has maintained the lowest food insecurity rate in the country for years. The structural difference is housing cost burden, which is significantly lower in Quebec due to rent controls, and a more comprehensive social safety net. The COVID comparison confirms that when income support is adequate, as it was during the CERB period, food insecurity falls almost immediately. The policy tools exist. They are being used more effectively in Quebec than elsewhere.

Finding three: Employment is no longer a reliable protection

Seven in ten food-insecure Canadians have jobs. The majority live above the official poverty line. Food insecurity has risen 43 percent since 2018 while employment rates have been broadly stable. The housing market has changed the fundamental arithmetic of working life in Canada. In cities like Vancouver and Toronto, a full-time worker earning the median wage can easily spend half or more of their take-home pay on rent, leaving almost nothing for food, transportation, or any unexpected expense. Addressing food insecurity through employment programs alone misses the point.

Finding four: The burden falls hardest on specific communities

Black Canadian families at 40.6 percent, Indigenous peoples at 36.8 percent, visible minorities overall at 27.6 percent, and female lone-parent families at 41.4 percent all face food insecurity at rates dramatically above the national average. These disparities persist even after controlling for income. They are not explained away by lower earnings alone. They reflect the additional structural barriers of racial discrimination in housing and labour markets, the effects of colonization and residential schools on Indigenous economic participation, and the structural disadvantage of raising children alone on a single income.

What a structural solution looks like

The data points toward three main levers. First, housing affordability. The strongest structural predictor of provincial food insecurity is tenant shelter burden. Policies that hold down rents, expand social housing, or provide housing subsidies to renters would directly reduce the share of income consumed by housing and leave more money for food. Quebec demonstrates this is achievable.

Second, income adequacy for people in precarious work. Because most food-insecure Canadians are employed, the solution involves ensuring that working incomes are sufficient to cover basic costs. This includes minimum wage levels, expanded benefits coverage for part-time and contract workers, and stronger labour protections.

Third, targeted support for the communities who bear disproportionate burden. Universal policies will not close the gap for Black, Indigenous, and female lone-parent households without additional targeted investment in affordable childcare, anti-discrimination enforcement in housing and hiring, and Indigenous-led economic development.

The data presented in this report does not advocate for a particular political party or ideology. It simply describes what exists, what it costs, and what the evidence suggests works. Quebec's outcomes show that lower food insecurity is achievable in Canada. The question is whether the political will exists to replicate what works.

Limitations and What This Analysis Cannot Claim

This analysis is honest about what it can and cannot show. Several important limitations should be kept in mind.

This is a provincial-level analysis. It compares 10 provinces to each other. That means all relationships are observed at the aggregate level and cannot be assumed to apply to individual households. A province with high average income can still have large numbers of very poor people within it. The provincial correlation between income and food insecurity being flat does not mean that poor families are not more likely to be food insecure. Within any province, lower-income households are at much higher risk. What the provincial comparison shows is that the overall wealth level of a province does not determine how well it protects its most vulnerable residents.

The analysis has only 10 data points for the provincial comparisons. This makes it very difficult to achieve the conventional thresholds of statistical significance, which is why many of the correlations are noted as not statistically significant. This does not mean the relationships are unimportant. It means that with only 10 provinces, the patterns observed could theoretically occur by chance even if the underlying relationship is real. The findings should be interpreted as suggestive rather than definitive.

The census income data refers to 2020, the pandemic year, when emergency transfers temporarily boosted many incomes and unemployment was elevated by pandemic closures. The food insecurity data for the comparison year is 2022. The two are not perfectly contemporaneous, which introduces some measurement noise.

City-level food insecurity data is available from published Statistics Canada research for only seven cities. The analysis cannot draw conclusions about other Canadian urban centres from the city-level findings.

Finally, the reliability flags on the Black Canadian and Indigenous food insecurity figures mean those specific estimates carry more uncertainty than the provincial figures. They are still the best available published data on the topic, and the direction of the disparity is unambiguous and consistent with extensive prior research. But the precise percentages should be read as approximations.

Sources and Further Reading

All data used in this analysis is publicly available and free to use under the Statistics Canada Open Licence. The direct links below will take you to each source.

Statistics Canada (2022). Census Profile, 2021 Census of Population, Provinces and Territories. Table 98-401-X2021001. Available at: <https://www12.statcan.gc.ca/census-recensement/2021/dp-pd/prof/>

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Tarasuk, V. and McIntyre, L. (2025). The evidence is in: accountability needs to be injected into the policy-making process for household food insecurity reduction. Health Promotion and Chronic Disease Prevention in Canada, 45(9), 386 to 390. <https://doi.org/10.24095/hpcdp.45.9.04>

The full analysis, including all Python code, cleaned datasets, and interactive visualizations, is available at: github.com/EdwardAgyemang/food-bank-poverty-canada

This report was produced as part of an independent data analytics project. The analysis and conclusions are those of the author. Statistics Canada data is reproduced under the Statistics Canada Open Licence.